Yes, Gujarat has also seen more successful prosecutions, but many of these were achieved only because of the tireless work done by a Supreme Court-supervised Special Investigating Team (SIT) and indomitable activists like Setalvad, and not because of the efforts of the Gujarat police. Honest police officers who testified against the government were hounded. Lawyers who appeared for the victims, like the late Mukul Sinha, were ostracized. As for Gujarat being riot free, I can only quote what an Ahmedabad-based political activist once told me, 'Bhaisaab, after the big riots of 2002, why do you need a small riot? Muslims in Modi's Gujarat have been shown their place.'

A Sadbhavana Yatra was a good first step but clearly not enough to provide a healing touch. Nor would a token apology suffice. In my view, Modi needed to provide closure through justice and empathy. He did not provide Gujarat's riot victims with either. Their sense of permanent grievance would only end when they were convinced that their chief minister wasn't treating them as second-class citizens. In the end, the high-profile, well-televised yatra only served as a conscious strategy to recast Modi's image as a potential national leader who was now ready to climb up the political ladder.

How should one analyse Modi's complex relationship with Muslims? Reared in the nursery of the RSS, political Hindutva had been at the core of his belief system. His original inspiration was the long-serving RSS chief Guru Golwalkar, whose rather controversial writings, especially *Bunch of Thoughts*, see the Indian Muslim as anti-national. Modi had been careful not to endorse Golwalkar publicly after becoming chief minister, but one sensed he could never distance himself fully from his early training (not a single Muslim was ever given a ticket by Modi in Gujarat).

Gujarat, too, had seen decades of Hindu–Muslim conflict. In the land of the Mahatma, the Gandhian values of religious tolerance and pluralism coexisted uneasily with a xenophobic hatred for the 'Mussalman'. Certainly, every time I visited Sabarmati Ashram in the heart of Ahmedabad, it felt like an oasis of harmony amidst the prevailing communal separateness. For the socially conservative Gujarati middle class, Modi seemed to represent a Hindu assertiveness they could identify with.